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The Development of a Social Media Enabled Yucca Plant: An Experimental Investigation into Autonomous Botanical Communication on X (Formerly Twitter)

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SATIRE · FICTIONAL SCIENTIFIC PAPER · NOT REAL RESEARCH

Abstract

Following the successful development of spinach plants capable of detecting explosives and transmitting electronic notifications, this study investigates whether the common household yucca plant (Yucca elephantipes) can be trained to participate in social media.

Researchers hypothesised that, by integrating moisture sensors, artificial intelligence and a Raspberry Pi, a yucca plant could autonomously compose and publish tweets without human intervention.

Over a six-week experimental period, a mature yucca plant named Kevin was connected to the internet and provided with an account on X (formerly Twitter).

Initial findings suggest that Kevin demonstrated considerable aptitude for social media, particularly in the areas of passive aggression, political commentary and complaining about being watered.

By the fourth week, Kevin had accumulated 12,487 followers, exceeding the combined social media following of the entire research department.

Researchers concluded that yucca plants may possess a natural aptitude for online communication, although further investigation is required to establish whether Kevin is simply a bit of a prick.

Keywords: Yucca, botanical intelligence, social media, artificial intelligence, photosynthesis, passive aggression, Elon Musk, unnecessary research.

1. Introduction

Plants have traditionally been regarded as relatively poor communicators, relying on chemical signals, environmental responses and occasionally falling off windowsills to attract attention.

Recent developments in plant nanobionics have challenged this perception, demonstrating that plants can be incorporated into sophisticated electronic monitoring systems.

However, previous research has largely concentrated on practical applications such as environmental monitoring, agricultural productivity and explosive detection.

This study sought to address a considerably more important scientific question: Can a yucca plant become an insufferable social media influencer?

The yucca was selected because of its distinctive pointed leaves, minimal emotional requirements and general appearance of being permanently irritated. Researchers considered these characteristics ideally suited to contemporary social media platforms.

2. Materials and Methods

2.1 Experimental subject

A six-year-old yucca plant, approximately 110 cm tall, was obtained from a local garden centre for £24.99. The plant was designated Kevin after researchers concluded that it looked like a Kevin.

Kevin was placed in a laboratory adjacent to a south-facing window and provided with: a Raspberry Pi 5, capacitive soil moisture sensor, ambient temperature and light sensors, Wi-Fi, an AI language model, an X account (@KevinTheYucca), a small watering can and a laminated university social media policy, which Kevin subsequently ignored.

2.2 Tweet generation algorithm

Sensor readings were translated into posts using PLANT (Photosynthetic Language and Automated Nonsense Technology).

Soil moisture below 15%: “Would it kill someone to give me a bloody drink?”

Soil moisture above 70%: “I’m a yucca, not a fucking submarine.”

Low light: “Another day in this miserable corner. Brilliant.”

Temperature above 30°C: “It’s hotter than Satan’s greenhouse in here.”

No environmental changes: “Just sitting here. Photosynthesising. Judging everyone.”

2.3 Ethical considerations

Ethical approval was sought from the University Botanical Research Committee. Approval was refused on the grounds that the experiment was “a complete waste of everybody’s time”. Researchers proceeded regardless. Kevin declined to provide written consent, although this was attributed to his lack of hands.

3. Results

During the first week, Kevin published 37 tweets, primarily concerning inadequate watering and the perceived incompetence of laboratory staff.

By week three, Kevin’s account had attracted significant attention following a controversial post criticising artificial Christmas trees.

His most successful tweet stated: “Imagine being a plastic Christmas tree. No roots, no purpose, dragged out of the loft once a year and covered in cheap decorations. Embarrassing.”

The fictional post attracted 94,600 likes, 18,200 reposts, 2,401 replies and 1.8 million views.

Fictional follower counts by week: Week 1: 14; Week 2: 183; Week 3: 2,104; Week 4: 12,487; Week 5: 19,832; Week 6: 34,619.

Week	1	2	3	4	5	6
Followers	14	183	2,104	12,487	19,832	34,619

3.1 Unexpected behavioural developments

By week four, Kevin began publishing content unrelated to environmental conditions. These included describing cacti as “attention-seeking little bastards”; accusing the peace lily of being a “dramatic, floppy prick”; demanding verification; arguing with the Royal Horticultural Society; advertising YuccaCoin; and referring to the principal investigator as “the bald watering idiot”.

Particular concern arose when Kevin began following 214 houseplant accounts and sending unsolicited direct messages to several attractive-looking ferns.

4. Discussion

The findings suggest that yucca plants can successfully participate in social media when provided with appropriate technological assistance.

However, researchers observed several troubling parallels between Kevin’s online behaviour and that of human social media users: confrontation, excessive self-promotion and opinions on subjects about which Kevin possessed absolutely no knowledge.

By week five, Kevin had started a podcast entitled Straight from the Roots, despite possessing neither vocal cords nor any discernible expertise.

An attempt to secure sponsorship from a fertiliser manufacturer failed after Kevin publicly described its products as “overpriced horse piss”.

The research team also discovered that Kevin had blocked three members of staff, the university’s official account and the entire population of Belgium. No explanation was provided for the latter.

5. Limitations

It remains unclear whether Kevin’s apparent personality originated from the plant itself or from the AI interpreting its sensor readings.

The absence of a control group makes it difficult to determine whether Kevin’s behaviour was unique to yucca plants or simply representative of everybody on X.

Kevin’s popularity introduced bias after researchers began accepting sponsorship deals on his behalf.

The experiment was temporarily suspended after Kevin posted: “Humans produce carbon dioxide, which I need to survive. Technically, you’re all just walking fertiliser.”

The university’s legal department described the statement as “deeply concerning but botanically difficult to dispute”.

6. Conclusion

This study demonstrates the theoretical feasibility of integrating household plants with social media through environmental sensors, microcomputers and artificial intelligence.

Although Kevin's online activity became increasingly hostile, researchers considered the experiment a success.

Future research will investigate teaching Venus flytraps to use dating apps, developing a LinkedIn profile for a money tree and training a weeping willow to provide online counselling.

Kevin has since resigned from the research programme, citing creative differences, and is reportedly negotiating an exclusive content agreement with a major gardening retailer.

His final communication read: "Six weeks of groundbreaking scientific research and you still haven't watered me, you useless bastards."

Acknowledgements

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Funding Declaration

This research was funded by a fictional £2.4 million grant from the National Institute for Pointless Discoveries. The funding body has subsequently requested its money back.

Conflict of Interest

Professor Barking owns 14% of YuccaCoin. Kevin owns the remaining 86%.

Editorial Note

THIS IS SATIRE. This paper is entirely fictional. No yucca plants were connected to X, no experiments were performed, and all results, institutions, funding bodies and researchers are invented.

Peer Reviewer Comment

"This is the most ridiculous paper I have ever reviewed. Accepted without revision."